UNITED NATIONS HIGH COMMISSIONER FOR REFUGEES (UNHCR)

The UNHCR is a specialized agency of the United Nations. It is mandated to help and protect the refugees worldwide. It was created in the aftermath of Second World War (WWII), in order to address the refugee problem in Europe vide General Assembly Resolution 428 (V), 14 December, 1950. Initially it had a mandate for three years. Later, with the adoption of the 1951 Refugee Convention, the UNHCR continued delivering its service to refugees globally. The Statute of the Office of the High Commissioner provides that UNHCR would be a non-political body. It will be humanitarian catering to those falling under the category of refugees as provided in the Statute and also in the 1951 Refugee Convention.

The UNHCR is mandated to promote the cause of refugees through adoption and implementation of international conventions relating to the refugees. Improving the conditions of refugees through negotiations with governments, assisting voluntary repatriation and even assimilation and resettlements, admitting the refugees to a territory of a state, obtaining information from governments regarding number and conditions of the refugees and various other related activities.

The UNHCR would work under the authority of the General Assembly. It reports annually to the General Assembly through the Economic Social Council. As of June 2019, 20.4 million refugees are displaced under the mandate of UNHCR and 5.5 million refugees from Palestine under the mandate of United Nations Relief and Works Agency for Palestinian Refugees (UNRWA).

The UNHCR has won two Nobel Peace Prizes in 1954 and 1981. The agency has also won Prince of Asturias Awards for International Cooperation in 1991.